

**FEDERAL SUPPLY SCHEDULE SOLE SOURCE JUSTIFICATION
FOR AN ORDER EXCEEDING
THE SIMPLIFIED ACQUISITION THRESHOLD
(AUTHORITY: GSAM/R 538.7104-3)**

Requisition Number: [REDACTED] / Requirements Workspace: [REDACTED]

This acquisition is conducted under the authority of the U.S. General Services Administration's (GSA) Federal Supply Schedule (FSS) Program.

1. Agency and contracting activity. Department of Commerce, National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) Acquisition and Grants Office (AGO), Corporate Services Acquisition Division (CSAD) and NOAA Office of Education (OEd).

2. Nature and/or description of the action being approved.

This is a sole source justification for a follow-on task order for scholarship support services to GMG Management Consulting (GMG). The now-expired, initial Blanket Purchase Agreement (BPA), 1305M423ANAAA0004, issued against Federal Supply Service (FSS) contract GS-00F-117CA, was awarded to GMG. The follow-on task order will be firm-fixed price, consisting of three Contract Line Item Numbers (CLINs) for each period of performance: one CLIN for labor (financial and administrative services); one CLIN for stipend payments; and one CLIN for travel expenses and other direct costs (ODCs).

3. Description of the supplies or services required to meet the agency's needs (including the estimated value).

OEd requires scholarship support services, to administer its two-year Ernest F. Hollings Undergraduate Scholarship Program (EFH USP) Class of 2026 and its one-year Educational Partnership Program Graduate Fellows Program (EPP GFP) Class of 2026. Scholarship support services generally consist of the timely disbursement of academic stipends, internship housing allowance, scholar travel reimbursements, and arrangement of student travel to domestic NOAA facilities for internship site visits, internships, orientation, symposium and professional conferences. Services also include arranging photographers, tour bus operators, caterers, ordering supplies and printing materials as needed to support events; and record-keeping, which allows OEd to respond in a timely manner to inquiries from NOAA, DOC and Congress about the purposeful use of the appropriated funds. The period of performance of task order will be a base year from May 1, 2026 - April 30, 2027; and the option year from May 2027 - April 2028.

The total estimated value of this procurement is [REDACTED].

4. Authority and supporting rationale. The following circumstance justifies a sole source as supported below:

Logical follow-on under the authority of GSAM/R 538.7104-3(b)(1)(iii) – The order should be issued on a sole source basis in the interest of economy and efficiency because it is a logical

follow-on to a previously awarded FSS BPA Order, 1305M423ANAAA0004/1305M424F0047, which expires April 30, 2026.

Awarding this bridge action to the incumbent contractor represents the most economical and efficient approach because the required services are unchanged from those previously competed under the BPA and transitioning performance to a new contractor at this time would result in substantial duplication of cost to the Government and operational inefficiencies that would not be recovered through competition. The original BPA was placed in accordance with applicable FSS ordering procedures and was not issued under sole source procedures.

BPA 1305M423ANAAA0004 was awarded on a competitive basis on September 21, 2023. The BPA included a period of performance consisting of one (1) base year and four (4) one-year option periods; the BPA was scheduled to expire on September 20, 2028, assuming timely award of all option periods.

The Contracting Officer issued a modification on September 18th, 2025, tailoring the Federal Acquisition Regulations (FAR) clause 52.217-9, Option to Extend the Term of the Contract, prior to the BPA's expiration on September 20, 2026. The Contracting Officer provided written notice to the contractor that the period for the option exercise was modified and extended through October 18, 2025 to allow time for its required political approval.

The BPA expired on October 18, 2025, which occurred during the Government shutdown between October 1, 2025 through November 12, 2025.

As a result of the BPA's expiration, the Government was unable to place subsequent orders necessary to support the second year of the EFH USP Class of 2025 and EPP GFP Class of 2026. Accordingly, a sole-source bridge action is required as a logical follow-on to the previously competed BPA to ensure continuity of services. The Government is currently planning a full and open competitive acquisition for the long-term requirement, and this bridge action will provide the limited period of performance necessary to complete that competition and transition to the resulting contract.

Execution of these programs by OEd is statutorily mandated (The EFH USP is authorized by Section 214 of the Consolidated Appropriations Act of 2005; The EPP awards are authorized under the America COMPETES Act Public Law 110–69) and funding is currently available; therefore, suspension or delay of program delivery would constitute an unacceptable disruption of mandated services. The two programs require similar broad categories of contractor services (e.g. periodic scholarship disbursements, approved travel expense reimbursement, logistical coordination of scholar travel and lodging, logistical coordination of introductory program orientation and program-concluding "Symposium" activities); however, efficient execution depends on a detailed understanding of important program-specific distinctions within each of these service areas.

Scholarship disbursement schedules differ significantly: EPP GFP requires biweekly disbursements throughout the year, while EFH USP requires bi-semester disbursements during the academic year and biweekly disbursements during the summer months. The different

programs permit different allowable expenses for scholars' professional development, with EPP GFP supporting more professional development services and expenses, while EFH USP offers fewer. Lodging allowances are structured differently as well—EPP GFP provides year-round lodging support whereas EFH USP provides nine- and ten-week allowances during one summer of the two-year program. In addition, each program operates under distinct approval and oversight protocols. Retaining GMG is the most **economical** solution, as they already maintain the systems, workflows, and institutional knowledge necessary to manage these program-specific distinctions, avoiding the additional costs, staff hours, and operational inefficiencies that would result from transitioning to a new contractor.

The combined scale of the EFH USP and EPP GFP programs further increase operational complexity and risk of execution inefficiency for a new contractor unfamiliar with program systems and workflows. The two classes supported by the task order will include nearly 200 scholars, all requiring concurrent scholarship payments, expense reimbursements, eligibility verification, and logistical coordination. Ongoing scholarship eligibility is conditional on the students submitting acceptable documentation for verification by the program. Historically, contractors have been challenged by this complex array of simultaneous, interrelated services and associated tracking, and have taken years to consistently deliver accurate services. Transitioning this requirement to a new contractor would require a start-up period to establish financial controls, scholar payment workflows, reimbursement procedures, and program coordination processes. During this period, the Government would incur additional oversight and management costs to onboard the new contractor, validate financial processes, and ensure accurate scholarship disbursements. Based on prior transitions, OEd estimates that validating a new contractor's operational and financial management processes would require approximately 200–300 additional Government staff hours during the initial months, duplicating work already completed under the BPA and increasing costs while reducing Government productivity without corresponding programmatic benefit.

The original 2023 BPA award codified GMG's [REDACTED] proposed labor rate escalation for each of the four option periods. In contrast, the Bureau of Labor Statistics reports escalations between [REDACTED] in the intervening period from award to the present. It is reasonable to assert that a new award to a non-incumbent contractor would be more likely to incur the BLS escalations, thereby increasing the economically adverse risk of a significantly higher price for the services.

Continuing performance with the incumbent contractor through this logical follow-on bridge action preserves economy and efficiency by avoiding these transition costs, maintaining established financial controls and workflows supporting nearly 300 scholars, and allowing the Government to conduct a full and open competition for the long-term requirement without disrupting service or delaying program delivery.

5. **Determination that the order represents the best value consistent with FAR 8.401, GSAM/R 538.7102-2(b)(4).**

The Contracting Officer will ensure the proposed pricing is in accordance with the contractor's GSA/FSS Schedule contract rates, which have already been determined fair and reasonable, and will seek additional discounts or price reductions, as appropriate. The Contracting Officer will also consider the level of effort required, and historical pricing for similar services. Award will be made only after determining that the final price represents the best value to the Government, consistent with GSAM/R 538.7103-3.

6. Market research conducted among schedule holders (or reason market research was not conducted).

The expired BPA was competitively awarded as a WOSB set-aside under FAR Part 8.4 acquisition. Extensive market research was previously performed in FY22 and FY23 in support of the competitively awarded BPA, and there have been no material changes to the requirement or the marketplace. The market research previously performed remains valid and is commensurate with the limited labor scope inherent to this requirement. Services to be delivered comprise only [REDACTED] of the resultant GSA/FSS task order's total value, with the remaining [REDACTED] reserved for scholarship disbursements, travel and ODC reimbursements. The required services are exactly the same as those performed under BPA order 1305M424F0047 and rely heavily on the incumbent contractor's institutional knowledge, established processes, and program-specific expertise developed over approximately eight years of performance. Additional market research was not conducted, as the current contractor's established institutional knowledge of the requirement sufficiently mitigates performance risk and supports continuity of services. (FAR 10.001(b))

7. Technical/Requirements Representative Certification.

I certify that this requirement constitutes the Government's minimum needs and the supporting data provided herein is accurate and complete to the best of my knowledge and belief.

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Christos Michalopoulos
Deputy Director, Office of Education

4/16/2026

Date

8. Office of General Counsel Review.

Review

ALEXIS PORTNOY
(Affiliate)

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Alexis Portnoy
Office of General Counsel/DOC

Date

9. Contracting Officer's Certification and Approval.

I certify that the circumstances of the acquisition deems only one source reasonably capable of providing the products, services, or solutions.

Approve

PERREN.CATHERINE.AGOSTINI.1365822596
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Catherine Perren
Contracting Officer

Date

10. Concurrence and Approval for Justifications >\$900k.

NOAA Competition Advocate:

Approve

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Binita Sharma
NOAA Competition Advocate

Date